# The Bondi dipole in full numerical relativity: a self-accelerating positive–negative mass binary

Nikita M. Shirokov[1, *] and Ilya Nachevsky[2, †]

[1] *Moscow Institute of Physics and Technology, Moscow, Russia*
[2] *Higher School of Economics, Moscow, Russia*

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Bondi showed in 1957 that a body of negative active gravitational mass and a positive one should accelerate together without limit while their total momentum stays zero. We test this prediction in full 3+1 numerical relativity, from constraint-satisfying initial data. The matter is two complex scalar fields with identical self-interactions, one of which enters the Einstein equations with the opposite sign; its stars have positive inertial and passive masses but negative active and Arnowitt–Deser–Misner (ADM) masses. To our knowledge, they are the first asymptotically flat bodies of negative ADM mass evolved in numerical relativity. A pair of stars with equal and opposite ADM masses accelerates as a single object at constant separation, and its total momentum, to which the negative-mass star contributes with a minus sign, stays zero to within 1%. The acceleration follows Newton's law of gravitation in both mass and separation, reverses when the stars are exchanged, and is absent in same-sign pairs and isolated stars. We detect no gravitational radiation. The results hold for head-on pairs released from rest, up to a few percent of the speed of light.

## I. INTRODUCTION

Bondi [1] distinguished three kinds of mass in general relativity: the inertial mass, which resists acceleration; the passive gravitational mass, on which a gravitational field acts; and the active gravitational mass, which sources the field. He showed that a body whose active mass alone is negative is attracted by a positive mass, while the positive mass is pushed away from it. Released together, the two accelerate in the same direction without limit (Fig. 1), and momentum is conserved because the negative body's momentum counts with a negative sign. Bonnor and Swaminarayan [2] found exact solutions for uniformly accelerated pairs of this kind, later generalized in Ref. [3]. Forward [5] showed that the self-accelerating pair conserves both momentum and energy, for equal and unequal mass magnitudes. Newtonian $N$-body simulations have since applied the same sign rules to cosmological structure formation [42, 43].

Nothing in the Einstein equations requires mass to be positive. Positivity of the total mass is a theorem only for matter that satisfies energy conditions [27, 28], and several candidate sources violate them: Casimir energies, quantum fields in curved spacetime and phantom dark energy [8]. Traversable wormholes [9] and warp-drive spacetimes [10] require such matter. The ghost scalar field, a field with a wrong-sign kinetic term, that holds a wormhole throat open violates the same energy condition as the negative-mass matter evolved here, though with different field equations (Sec. II). Bondi's self-accelerating pair is itself a standing objection to all such matter, since a pair that accelerates without an external force looks like a perpetual-motion machine [6, 7]. That objection has been examined for point particles and prescribed metrics. The existing nonlinear evolutions of matter that violates energy conditions concern single objects: ghost-scalar wormholes in spherical symmetry [15, 30], static stars of phantom fields [31], and the collapse of an Alcubierre warp bubble in 3+1 dimensions [11]. Negative-mass bubbles in de Sitter space [29] and negative-mass black holes [12] have also been studied. Here we test whether the self-acceleration survives full nonlinear gravity, with finite bodies, backreaction and radiation, for a self-gravitating pair of positive and negative active mass with dynamical, constraint-solved matter.

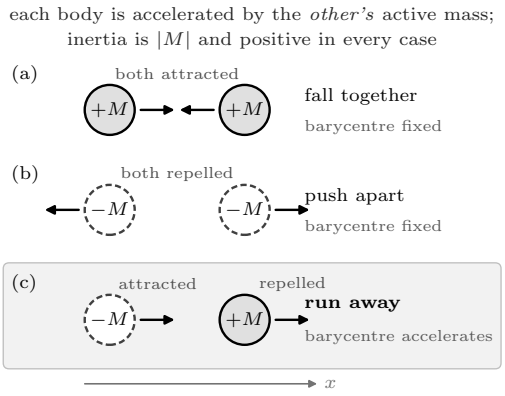



FIG. 1. Bondi's sign rules for two bodies released from rest, after Forward [5]. Every body has positive inertial and passive mass; the active mass of the dashed bodies is negative. (a) Two positive masses attract and (b) two negative masses repel; in both cases the forces are opposite and the barycentre stays at rest. (c) For a positive and a negative mass both forces point the same way, so the pair accelerates while its total momentum stays zero.

The question also has observational interest. Negative-mass binaries have been proposed as sources of anoma-

* shirokov.nm@phystech.edu
† ommnammashivaya@gmail.com

lous gravitational-wave signals, such as anti-chirps, dispersal and runaway motion, which detectors could use to exclude them [39]. Nojiri and Odintsov [13] find that a bound positive–negative system can form around a compact mass in a cosmological fluid with a negative cosmological constant. We study the complementary case of an isolated, asymptotically flat pair.

In this paper we realize Bondi's sign structure with two complex scalar fields that obey the same field equation, one of which enters the Einstein equations with a negative sign (Sec. II). Both fields form solitonic boson stars, bound by their own self-interaction, which we construct as constraint-satisfying initial data (Sec. III). We evolve them with `GRTeclyn` [24], the GPU port of `GRChombo` [23] built on AMReX [26], in 34 simulations that include same-sign pairs and isolated stars as controls. The simulations cover head-on pairs released from rest in the weak-field regime, evolved to $t = 200$ at up to three resolutions, with longer runs to $t = 400$ for a pair and $t = 1000$ for an isolated star. Section IV gives the numerical methods, the diagnostics and the five predictions of Bondi's argument that we test; Sec. V gives the results, Sec. VI the gravitational radiation, Sec. VII the systematic checks, and Sec. VIII our conclusions. We use units with $G = c = 1$ and scalar mass $m = 1$.

## II. THE MODEL

The matter must meet three requirements: (i) positive inertial and passive mass with negative active mass; (ii) stable, localized stars; and (iii) a binding force other than gravity for the negative-mass star, whose own gravity pushes it apart. The obvious candidates each fail one of them. The negative-mass Schwarzschild spacetime is a naked singularity whose linear perturbations grow exponentially [14], and it contains no matter from which to build initial data. A fluid of negative energy density has no equilibrium of its own: Bonnor's static negative-mass spheres [4] require an inverted interior structure that no non-gravitational force supports. A ghost field (a phantom field in the language of cosmology [8]) carries the sign of its kinetic term into its own field equation. This inverts its effective potential, which unbinds the star, and it makes the inertial and passive masses negative together with the active mass, as for Forward's negative matter [5]. Such fields collapse or explode in evolutions [15, 30, 45]. We instead reverse the overall sign of one field's Lagrangian, Eq. (2) below, which leaves its field equation unchanged and reverses only its stress-energy tensor.

The stars are solitons: matter bound by its own self-interaction, with gravity a small correction rather than the binding force. We use two independent complex scalar fields, $\Phi_+$ and $\Phi_-$, on one spacetime, with the same sextic potential as in studies of Q-balls and solitonic boson stars [16–18],

$$V(|\Phi|^2) = \tfrac{1}{2}m^2|\Phi|^2 - \tfrac{1}{4}\lambda|\Phi|^4 + \tfrac{1}{6}\mu|\Phi|^6, \qquad (1)$$

where $m$ is the scalar mass and $\lambda, \mu > 0$ are the quartic and sextic couplings: the mass term makes the field oscillate, the attractive quartic term binds it into a star, and the repulsive sextic term prevents the star's collapse. Because the two fields share one potential, their matter physics is identical, and the sign introduced next is the only difference between them.

The model is defined by the action

$$S = \int d^4x\,\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{{}^{(4)}R}{16\pi} + \mathcal{L}[\Phi_+] - \mathcal{L}[\Phi_-]\right], \qquad (2)$$

where $g$ is the determinant of the spacetime metric, ${}^{(4)}R$ its Ricci scalar, and $\mathcal{L}[\Phi] = -\frac{1}{2}\nabla_\mu\Phi^*\nabla^\mu\Phi - V(|\Phi|^2)$. Varying Eq. (2) with respect to each field gives the same Klein–Gordon equation for both,

$$\Box\,\Phi_\pm = 2\,\frac{\partial V}{\partial|\Phi|^2}\,\Phi_\pm, \qquad (3)$$

because the overall sign of a field's Lagrangian cancels from its own Euler–Lagrange equation; the factor 2 comes from the $\frac{1}{2}$ in the kinetic term. Varying with respect to the metric gives

$$G_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi\left(T_{\mu\nu}[\Phi_+] - T_{\mu\nu}[\Phi_-]\right), \qquad (4)$$

where $T_{\mu\nu}[\Phi]$ is the standard stress-energy tensor of a complex scalar field, and the sign of the Lagrangian carries over to the source.

Equations (3) and (4) are consistent with each other and with the Bianchi identity $\nabla^\mu G_{\mu\nu} = 0$. Each field's stress-energy tensor is conserved on solutions of its own field equation (3), so the signed sum on the right of Eq. (4) is conserved as well. The negative source $-T_{\mu\nu}[\Phi_-]$ violates the null energy condition (NEC), $T_{\mu\nu}k^\mu k^\nu \geq 0$ for every null vector $k^\mu$, wherever $\Phi_- \neq 0$. A field that gravitates with negative energy admits vacuum decay through graviton exchange [32, 33], so we make no claim about the model's quantum consistency and use it as a classical probe of how gravity would act on such matter, as in phantom cosmology [8]. The sign enters the evolution equations, which we write in the conformal and covariant Z4 (CCZ4) formulation (Sec. IV), only through algebraic source terms, so their principal part is that of CCZ4 with ordinary scalar matter.

The field $\Phi_-$ therefore moves like ordinary matter, with positive inertial and passive mass, but sources gravity with a negative sign, so its active mass is negative, and so is the ADM mass of an isolated $\Phi_-$ star. We call the stars of $\Phi_+$ and $\Phi_-$ positive-mass and negative-mass stars; a mixed pair has one star of each field, a same-sign pair two stars of one field. We use the 3+1 split with lapse $\alpha$, shift $\beta^i$ and spatial metric $\gamma_{ij}$, and $n^\mu$ the unit normal to the spatial slices. The Einstein equations are then sourced by the energy density $\rho = n^\mu n^\nu T_{\mu\nu}$, the momentum density $S_i = -\gamma_i{}^\mu n^\nu T_{\mu\nu}$ and the stress $S_{ij} = \gamma_i{}^\mu\gamma_j{}^\nu T_{\mu\nu}$, the projections of the total stress-energy tensor measured by observers moving along $n^\mu$.

Each field contributes with its sign $\epsilon_\pm = \pm 1$,

$$\rho = \sum_{s=\pm} \epsilon_s \, \rho[\Phi_s], \qquad S_i = \sum_{s=\pm} \epsilon_s \, S_i[\Phi_s], \tag{5}$$

and likewise for $S_{ij}$, where each bracket is the standard expression for one complex scalar field.

The action (2) has no term that couples $\Phi_+$ to $\Phi_-$, so stars of different fields interact only through the metric: in the mixed pair, gravity is the only interaction by construction. Two stars of the same field also attract each other directly through the field's self-interaction where they overlap. This short-range attraction does not depend on the sign of the mass; Sec. V E measures it, and the mixed pair cannot have it.

## III. INITIAL DATA

### A. Isolated stars

A star of this model is a solution in which the field oscillates with a single frequency, $\Phi = \varphi_0(r) e^{-i\omega t}$; the frequency $\omega$ labels the family of solutions, with $\omega = m$ the free-field limit. The ratio $\lambda^2/\mu$ sets the lowest frequency a star can have, $\omega_{\min} = \sqrt{1 - 3\lambda^2/16\mu}$ [17]. All our stars use $\lambda^2/\mu = 4.8$ (Table I), so $\omega_{\min} = 0.316$.

A star built in flat space violates the constraints once its own gravity is included, so we solve for each star together with its gravity, as for boson stars [19–21] with a sextic potential, for both signs of the source. We take a conformally flat spatial metric, $\gamma_{ij} = \psi^4 \delta_{ij}$ with conformal factor $\psi$, and maximal slicing, $K = 0$, where $K$ is the trace of the extrinsic curvature. Equations (3) and (4) then reduce to ordinary differential equations for $\psi(r)$, $\alpha(r)$ and $\varphi_0(r)$. The negative-mass star solves the same equations with the sign of the matter source reversed in the metric equations only. Its gravity is repulsive: $\psi < 1$ and $\alpha > 1$ in its core. We solve the equations by shooting at fixed frequency, bisecting in the central amplitude, and iterate until the frequency measured at infinity, $\omega/\alpha_\infty$, matches the requested value to $\sim 10^{-5}$.

Figure 2 shows both families. The reference pair consists of a positive-mass star at $\omega = 0.750$ and a negative-mass star at $\omega = 0.7603$ (Table I), whose ADM masses $M_\pm$ satisfy $|M_-| = M_+$ to 0.4%; we call such a pair an equal-mass pair. Equal ADM masses are the relevant match because, in Bondi's point-mass limit, each body acts on the other through its exterior field, which the ADM mass sets. We write $\bar{M} = \frac{1}{2}(M_+ + |M_-|)$ for the mean mass of a pair. The positive-mass star has a root-mean-square (rms) radius $r_{\rm rms} = 4.34$, the rms distance from its barycentre weighted by $w_s = (|\Phi_s|^2 + |\Pi_s|^2)^{1/2}$, where $\Pi_s$ is the conjugate momentum of $\Phi_s$. Its compactness, $M_+/r_{\rm rms} \sim 3 \times 10^{-3}$, is far from that of horizon formation. Four isolated positive-mass stars with $\omega = 0.75$ to 0.90, evolved to $t = 120$, keep their minimum lapse within $1.2 \times 10^{-3}$ of its initial value. Each star's conjugate momentum is set from the lapse of its own solution, $\Pi = -(\omega/\alpha(r))\,\varphi_0(r)$, so that it starts in its stationary state.

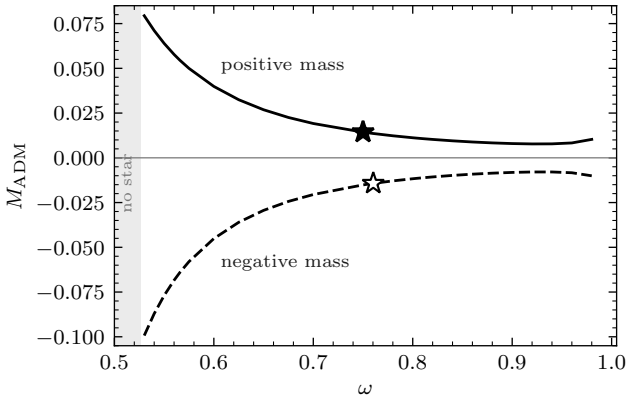



FIG. 2. ADM mass of isolated stars against the oscillation frequency $\omega$, for positive-mass (solid) and negative-mass (dashed) stars at the couplings used here. Star symbols: the two stars of the reference pair. At equal $\omega$ the negative-mass star is heavier in magnitude, and neither family has a star lighter than about 0.54 of the reference mass.

### B. The pair

We place the two stars at $x = \pm d_0/2$ about the centre of the domain, where $d_0$ is the initial separation, and superpose their fields. `GRTresna` [25] then solves the Hamiltonian and momentum constraints for the pair, with each field's sources entering with its sign. Two choices in this step matter for the measurement.

*Both stars on the same slicing.* `GRTresna` implements the CTTK method [35], a variant of the conformal transverse-traceless (CTT) decomposition that can solve the Hamiltonian constraint algebraically for $K$, with $K \propto \sqrt{\rho}$. This is imaginary where $\rho < 0$, so the negative-mass star requires the maximal-slicing option, $K = 0$, which solves for $\psi$ instead. If the positive-mass star is built with the algebraic option, the two stars are built by different methods, and the positive-mass star starts with a large initial $K$, $\max|K| \approx 0.1$, four orders of magnitude above that of the negative-mass star. We therefore use $K = 0$ for both stars. This removes the initial transient in $K$ ($\max|K| \approx 10^{-5}$), and the two constructions then differ only in the sign of $\rho$.

*The same grid spacing for the solve and the evolution.* The elliptic solve runs on a domain twice the size of the evolution domain. If its grid spacing differs from that of the evolution, the metric interpolated onto the evolution grid is displaced from the scalar field by a fraction of a cell, so each star starts away from the centre of its own gravitational potential. This causes a drift that does not converge away with resolution and is as large as the effect we measure. We therefore solve on the evolution's grid spacing, so that the cell centres coincide and the metric

TABLE I. Model and numerical parameters, in units $G = c = m = 1$.

| | |
|---|---|
| Couplings | $\lambda = 10240$, $\mu = 2.18 \times 10^7$ ($\lambda^2/\mu = 4.8$) |
| Reference stars | $\omega = 0.750$, $M_+ = +0.014350$; $\omega = 0.7603$, $M_- = -0.014295$; $\bar{M} = 0.014322$; $r_{\rm rms} = 4.34$; central field amplitude 0.019 |
| Formulation | CCZ4 [22], $(\kappa_1, \kappa_2, \kappa_3) = (3, 0, 1)$ |
| Gauge | 1+log slicing [36]; Gamma-driver shift [37, 38], $\eta = 1$ |
| Discretization | fourth-order finite differences; fourth-order Runge–Kutta, $\Delta t = 0.02\,\Delta x$ |
| Dissipation | Kreiss–Oliger, $\sigma = 2$ |
| Grid | uniform cube of side $L = 64$; $N = 128$, 192, 256 cells per side ($\Delta x = 0.50$, 0.33, 0.25) |
| Boundaries | Sommerfeld; absorbing layer at $24 \le r \le 32$ |
| Initial data | `GRTresna` [25], CTTK [35] with $K = 0$, on a domain of side $2L$ with the same $\Delta x$ |

is copied cell by cell onto the evolution grid, while the scalar field is set on that grid from each star's radial profile. The offset between the centroids of the metric perturbation and of the matter is then below $10^{-4}$, the precision of that measurement, in every simulation.

Both stars are given the same internal phase. For the mixed pair the relative phase has no effect, because the two fields do not couple. For two stars of the same field it matters: two Q-balls in phase attract each other through the shared field, and two in antiphase repel [40, 41]. Our same-sign pairs therefore start in the attracting configuration, consistent with the mergers of Sec. V E. Superposed data for two stars of one field also carry phase-dependent constraint errors, which the constraint solve reduces but does not remove [34]; we use these pairs only as controls for the centroid motion.

## IV. NUMERICAL METHODS, DIAGNOSTICS AND TESTS

### A. Evolution

We evolve the Einstein equations in the CCZ4 formulation [22] with the gauge, discretization and dissipation of Table I. The CCZ4 variable $\chi = (\det \gamma_{ij})^{-1/3}$, equal to $\psi^{-4}$ on the conformally flat initial data, is below 1 in a positive-mass star and above 1 in a negative-mass star. The time step is $\Delta t = 0.02\,\Delta x$, an order of magnitude below the usual CCZ4 value: it is set by the stability of the sextic self-interaction, and at $\Delta t = 0.2\,\Delta x$ the star disperses. Outgoing waves of a massive field reflect from the Sommerfeld outer boundary conditions, which are designed for massless waves, so an absorbing layer, extra Kreiss–Oliger dissipation that rises with radius, covers $24 \le r \le 32$. With it, the net scalar-field energy flux into the domain, measured on a sphere near the boundary, stays below $10^{-7}$, even for the same-sign pairs.

All simulations use a uniform grid without adaptive mesh refinement (AMR), so a change of resolution is a change of the grid spacing alone. The three resolutions of Table I put about 9, 13 and 17 grid points across the rms radius of a star. One simulation doubles the side to $L = 128$ at $N = 256$ ($\Delta x = 0.50$), with the absorbing layer at $48 \le r \le 60$, to extract gravitational waves at larger radii. The reference initial separation is $d_0 = 10$, about twice the radius that contains 90% of a star's weight $w_s$; other pairs use $d_0 = 8$ to 20. Every pair is released from rest, without a boost, so any motion is dynamical. Most simulations end at $t = 200$; Table II lists the exceptions. Each simulation ran on one NVIDIA H100 GPU; a simulation to $t = 200$ takes about 1, 5 and 15 hours at $N = 128$, 192 and 256.

### B. Diagnostics

We track each field in two ways. Its barycentre

$$\bar{x}^{(s)} = \frac{\int x\, w_s\, d^3x}{\int w_s\, d^3x}, \qquad w_s = \left(|\Phi_s|^2 + |\Pi_s|^2\right)^{1/2}, \quad (6)$$

is computed over the whole domain. Its core position is the $w_s^4$-weighted centroid of the cells where $w_s$ exceeds a quarter of its maximum, which ignores the low-amplitude field a star sheds. The main diagnostic is the midpoint of the two stars and its displacement,

$$X = \tfrac{1}{2}\left(\bar{x}^{(+)} + \bar{x}^{(-)}\right), \qquad \Delta X(t) = X(t) - X(0), \quad (7)$$

which Bondi's argument predicts to accelerate. For a same-sign pair, the centroid of the pair is the barycentre of its single field, Eq. (6); by symmetry it stays at rest. The two ways of tracking agree on $\Delta X$ of the mixed pair to 1%. The separation $d$ is the coordinate distance between the two barycentres; we also measure the proper distance between the two cores along the axis, $\int \sqrt{\gamma_{xx}}\, dx$. The acceleration $a$ is twice the quadratic coefficient of the least-squares fit

$$X(t) = X_0 + v_0\, t + \tfrac{1}{2}\, a\, t^2, \qquad 5 \le t \le t_{\rm end}, \quad (8)$$

which leaves out the first five time units while the gauge adjusts. For point masses with $|M_-| = M_+$, each star is accelerated by the other's active mass, and Bondi's argument predicts

$$a = \frac{\bar{M}}{d^2}. \quad (9)$$

The matter momentum of each field and their signed total are

$$P^{(s)} = \int S_x[\Phi_s]\, \sqrt{\gamma}\, d^3x, \qquad P = P^{(+)} - P^{(-)}, \quad (10)$$

with $\gamma = \det \gamma_{ij}$. We also record the $L_2$ norms of the Hamiltonian and momentum constraints over the domain, the multipoles of the Newman–Penrose scalar $\Psi_4$, which carries outgoing gravitational waves, on spheres of radius $R$, and the energy conditions. The isolated positive-mass star satisfies the NEC everywhere.

### C. Tests

Bondi's argument makes five predictions for a mixed pair with $|M_-| = M_+$, and each has a control: (i) the midpoint $X$ accelerates at a constant rate while the separation $d$ stays constant; (ii) the signed matter momentum $P$ stays zero while the momentum of each field grows; (iii) the acceleration follows Eq. (9), $a \propto d^{-2}$ at fixed mass and $a \propto \bar{M}$ at fixed separation, and each star responds to its partner's mass; (iv) exchanging the two stars reverses the acceleration; (v) configurations without a mass dipole, the same-sign pairs and the isolated stars, stay at rest: neither the centroid of a same-sign pair nor the core of an isolated star moves. A numerical artefact would fail at least one of these tests: it need not reverse when the stars are exchanged, need not follow $d^{-2}$ or the partner's mass, and would also appear in the controls.

## V. RESULTS

### A. The mixed pair accelerates at constant separation

Does the mixed pair accelerate as a single object (test i)? In the reference simulation, PM10 at $N = 256$, the positive-mass star starts at $x = 37$ and the negative-mass star at $x = 27$, and both accelerate toward $+x$ (Figs. 3 and 4). The midpoint moves $\Delta X = 3.00 \pm 0.01$ by $t = 200$, and a single parabola, Eq. (8), fits the whole trajectory with $a = (1.55 \pm 0.01) \times 10^{-4}$; the error bars are the difference between $N = 192$ and 256 (Sec. VII A). The acceleration stays constant in a longer run: in PM10-t400, fits over $133 \le t \le 266$ and $300 \le t \le 400$ agree to 2%, and the pair reaches $0.056c$ at $t = 400$. Over $t \le 200$ the separation stays constant to 1%, both as the coordinate distance between the barycentres and as the proper distance between the cores (Table III).

The stars keep their structure while they accelerate. Their peak field amplitude changes by less than 0.3%, the minimum lapse stays above 0.99, and the minimum of $\chi$ stays above 0.98, far from collapse, which would drive $\chi$ toward zero.

### B. The signed momentum stays zero

Does the total momentum stay zero while the stars move (test ii)? The matter momentum of each field grows steadily, while the signed total $P$ of Eq. (10) stays below 1% of either term (Fig. 4d and Table III). This residual decreases by a factor of ten between $N = 128$ and 256, consistent with a discretization error. $P$ is the matter momentum rather than the ADM momentum; we expect the difference, the momentum carried by the gravitational field, to be small at compactness $3 \times 10^{-3}$.

### C. The acceleration follows $a = \bar{M}/d^2$

Does the acceleration follow Eq. (9) (test iii)? Five pairs with $d_0 = 8$ to 20 test the dependence on separation (Fig. 5a,b). A power law through their accelerations gives $a \propto d^{-2.03 \pm 0.01}$. The ratio $a\,d^2/\bar{M}$ falls from 1.03 at $d_0 = 8$ to 1.00 for $d_0 \ge 12$, as expected for a finite-size correction, which is largest where the two stars overlap most. The signed momentum $P$ at $t = 200$ falls with separation as the acceleration does.

These five simulations ran at $N = 128$, whose acceleration at $d_0 = 10$ lies 7% below the $N = 256$ value. If this truncation error is the same for all five, it cancels from the exponent and from every ratio in Sec. V F. It does not cancel from the absolute values: at $N = 256$, the acceleration of the reference pair lies 8% above $\bar{M}/d^2$, so at a separation of two stellar diameters Eq. (9) holds to about 10%.

Four equal-mass pairs at $d_0 = 20$, where the finite-size correction is 0.2%, test the dependence on mass (Fig. 5c,d). In each pair both stars were constructed at new frequencies so that $|M_-| = M_+$, since an unequal pair changes its separation (Sec. V F) and Eq. (8) then no longer applies. Over a factor 2.46 in $\bar{M}$ the accelerations give $a \propto \bar{M}^{0.97 \pm 0.06}$, and each pair's $a\,d^2/\bar{M}$ lies within 2.4% of 1. These values use the core positions, which ignore the field a star sheds; the barycentres give a steeper exponent, because the lightest pair is the most diffuse and sheds the most field.

### D. Exchanging the stars reverses the acceleration

Does the motion reverse when the two stars are exchanged (test iv)? MP10 is PM10 at $N = 128$ with the two stars swapped in place. Its $\Delta X(200)$ and its acceleration are those of PM10 with the opposite sign, to two parts in $10^5$. This excludes any asymmetry of the numerical method that does not depend on which star carries the negative mass, such as a biased stencil, an asymmetric domain or a direction-dependent diagnostic. It does not exclude an artefact sourced by the matter, which would reverse as well, but tests (iii) and (v) exclude it.

### E. Pairs without a mass dipole stay at rest

Do pairs without a mass dipole stay at rest (test v)? An isolated star moves its core by at most $1.8 \times 10^{-3}$ on

TABLE II. The 34 simulations. Labels name the stars, P for a positive-mass and M for a negative-mass star, followed by the initial separation $d_0$; E labels equal-mass pairs by $\bar{M}$ relative to PM20, R unequal-mass pairs by $|M_-|/M_+$, and S isolated stars by $\omega$. Unless stated, a simulation uses the stars of the reference pair and the domain $L = 64$.

| Label | Configuration | $N$ | $t_{\rm end}$ | Purpose |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| PM10 | mixed pair, $d_0 = 10$ | 128, 192, 256 | 200 | reference; resolution study |
| PM8, PM12, PM16, PM20 | mixed pair, $d_0 = 8$, 12, 16, 20 | 128 | 200 | dependence on separation |
| E0.64, E1.34, E1.57 | as PM20, both stars constructed at new frequencies, with $\|M_-\| = M_+$ (to 0.02%) and $\bar{M}$ equal to 0.64, 1.34 and 1.57 times that of PM20 | 128 | 200 | dependence on mass |
| R0.60, R0.80, R1.33 | as PM10, one star constructed at a new frequency, so that $\|M_-\|/M_+ =$ 0.60, 0.80, 1.33 | 128 | 200 | unequal masses |
| MP10 | as PM10, the two stars exchanged | 128 | 200 | reversal |
| PM10-t400 | as PM10 | 128 | 400 | constancy of $a$ |
| PM10-rec | as PM10, domain recentred on the pair during the run | 128 | 784 | separation after $t = 200$ |
| PM10-off | as PM10, pair started 10 units off centre in a fixed domain | 128 | 600 | separation after $t = 200$ |
| PM10-tol | as PM10, elliptic-solver tolerance 4.4 times tighter | 128 | 200 | initial-data accuracy |
| PM10-AMR | as PM10, adaptive mesh refinement allowed | 128 | 200 | grid structure |
| PM10-$\eta$2 | as PM10, shift damping $\eta = 2$ | 128 | 200 | gauge |
| PM10-L128 | as PM10, $L = 128$ ($\Delta x = 0.50$) | 256 | 200 | domain size; wave extraction |
| PP10 | two positive-mass stars, $d_0 = 10$ | 128, 192, 256 | 200 | same-sign control |
| MM10 | two negative-mass stars, $d_0 = 10$ | 128 (two runs), 192 | 200 | same-sign control |
| P | isolated positive-mass star at the centre of the domain | 128 | 200 | isolated control |
| M, M-t1000 | isolated negative-mass star, 5 units off centre | 128 | 200, 1000 | isolated control |
| S0.75–S0.90 | isolated positive-mass stars with $\omega =$ 0.75, 0.80, 0.85, 0.90 | 128 | 120 | stationarity of the stars |

any axis over $t \leq 200$, both at the centre of the domain (P) and five units off centre (M), where no symmetry holds it in place; this is over a thousand times less than $\Delta X$. The barycentre of the off-centre negative-mass star, the quantity that corresponds to the barycentres used for $\Delta X$, moves $1.3 \times 10^{-2}$, still about 200 times less.

The same-sign pairs merge, PP10 at $t = 33.6$ and MM10 at $t = 32.8$ (Fig. 6a). Gravity attracts the two positive masses and repels the two negative ones (Fig. 1), so if gravity set the timescale, PP10 would merge while MM10 flew apart. The stars are instead pulled together by their shared field (Sec. II). The required strength is consistent with this: Newtonian free fall from $d = 10$ at these masses takes $t \approx 207$, so merging at $t \approx 33$ requires a force about 35 to 40 times that of gravity. Through infall, merger and the oscillations that follow, the centroids of both same-sign pairs move by less than $8 \times 10^{-4}$ at every resolution, four orders of magnitude below $\Delta X$ (Fig. 6b). The merged objects keep the sign of $\chi - 1$, with $\min \chi = 0.979$ for PP10 and $\max \chi = 1.011$ for MM10.

The same comparison shows that the field attraction is absent from the mixed pair, whose two stars are different fields with no coupling. At $d_0 = 10$, where same-field pairs merge within $t \approx 33$, the separation of the mixed pair stays constant to 1% for $t \leq 200$; even a few percent of a force 35 times gravity would have changed $d$ by much more than 1%. The mixed pair's acceleration also falls as a power of the separation, whereas an overlap force falls exponentially, and it follows the partner's ADM mass (Sec. V F), on which a force through the field does not depend.

The isolated negative-mass star evolved to $t = 1000$ (M-t1000) reproduces M up to $t = 200$ and then neither collapses nor disperses. Its peak field amplitude decreases linearly, by 0.63% per 100 time units after $t \approx 200$, while its rms radius grows from 4.41 to 4.83 and the minimum of $\chi$ stays above 1. The star slowly relaxes outward; we quote this decay rate for the evolved time, not as a statement about stability at later times.

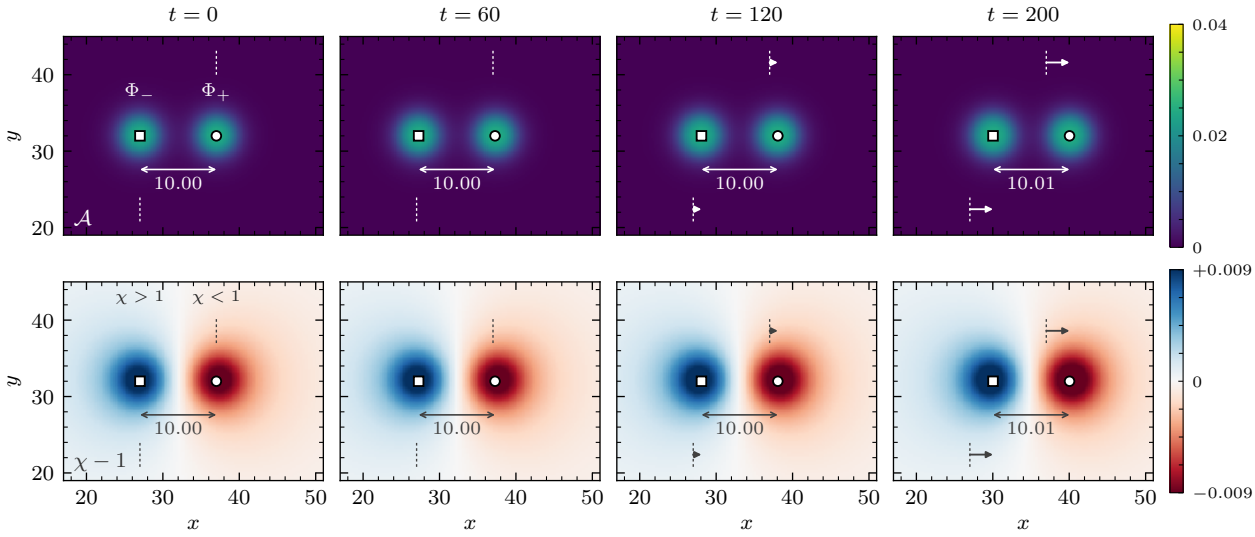



FIG. 3. The reference simulation (PM10, $N = 256$) in the plane $z = 0$ at $t = 0$, 60, 120 and 200. Top: the sum of the weights $w_s$ of Eq. (6). Bottom: $\chi - 1$, positive for the negative-mass star (left, blue) and negative for the positive-mass star (right, red). Colour scales are fixed across snapshots. Circles and squares mark the cores of $\Phi_+$ and $\Phi_-$, dashed ticks the initial positions, arrows the displacement, and the number between the stars the separation $d$. Both stars move toward $+x$ at constant acceleration while $d$ stays constant to 1%. Movie: Video 1, youtu.be/egzPDbz2_B0.

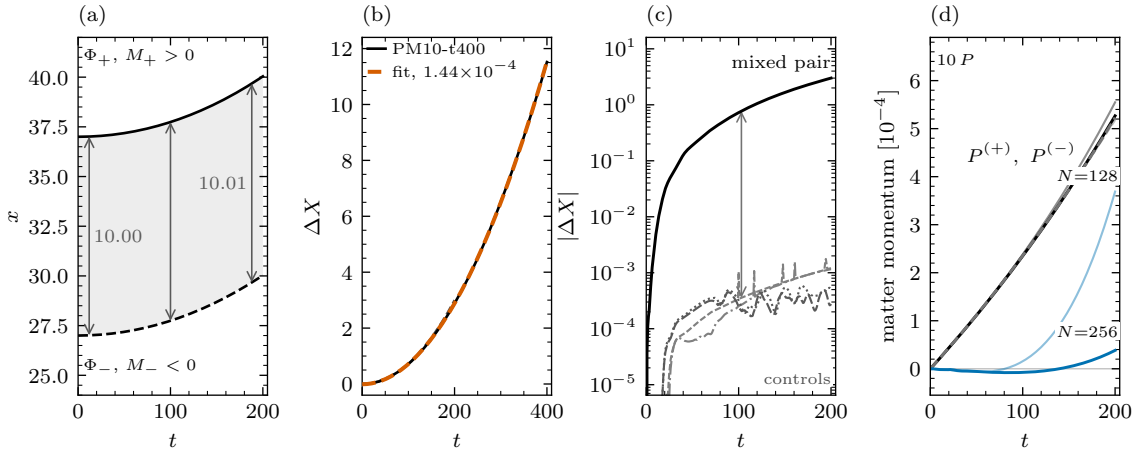



FIG. 4. (a) Core positions of the positive-mass (solid) and negative-mass (dashed) star in the reference simulation, with the separation at three times. (b) $\Delta X$ of PM10-t400 (solid) and one constant-acceleration fit, Eq. (8), over $5 \le t \le 400$ (dashed). (c) $|\Delta X|$ of the mixed pair (black) against the core displacement of the isolated stars and the centroid displacement of the same-sign pairs (grey), on a log scale. (d) Matter momentum of each field, $P^{(+)}$ and $P^{(-)}$, and ten times their signed total $P$ (blue; light $N = 128$, dark $N = 256$), Eq. (10). The pair moves three units while $P$ stays below 1% of either field's momentum. Movie: Video 2, youtu.be/zZcr2N12aww.

### F. Each star follows its partner's mass

Does each star respond to its partner's mass (test iii)? In Bondi's argument, changing one star's mass changes its partner's acceleration and leaves its own unchanged. Three unequal-mass pairs at $d_0 = 10$ test this (Fig. 7). We constructed the negative-mass star anew at $\omega = 0.88$ and 0.804, which gives $|M_-|/M_+ = 0.60$ and 0.80, and the positive-mass star at $\omega = 0.81$, which gives 1.33. Because the separation now changes, we fit each star's acceleration constant $C$ in $\ddot{x} = \pm C/d(t)^2$ with the measured $d(t)$, by regressing the core position $x(t)$ on $\{1, t, I_2(t)\}$ for $t \ge 5$, where $I_2$ is the double time integral of $d^{-2}$. When a star's partner is changed, its acceleration scales with the partner's mass to within 0.9 to 3.1%; when the partner is unchanged, the acceleration stays within 2.8% of its PM10 value (Table III). No lighter partner exists at these couplings: both families have a minimum $|M|$ near 0.54 of the reference mass (Fig. 2).

Unequal masses also change the separation, in the di-

TABLE III. Measured results against Bondi's predictions, by simulation (Table II). The $C$ ratio compares a star's fitted acceleration constant $C$, in $\ddot{x} = \pm C/d^2$, with its value in PM10 (Sec. V F).

| Simulation | Quantity | Measured | Expected |
|---|---|---|---|
| PM10, $N = 256$ | $\Delta X(200)$ | $3.00 \pm 0.01$ | 2.86 for $a = \bar{M}/d_0^2$ |
| PM10, $N = 256$ / 192 / 128 | $a$ $[10^{-4}]$ | 1.55 / 1.56 / 1.45 | 1.43 |
| PM10, $N = 256$ | $\lvert P\rvert/P^{(+)}$ at $t = 200$ | 0.007 | 0 |
| PM10, $N = 256$ | change of $d$ over $t \le 200$: barycentres; proper | $-0.9\%$; $+0.24\%$ | 0 |
| PM10-t400 | $a$ over $133 \le t \le 266$; $300 \le t \le 400$ $[10^{-4}]$ | 1.45; 1.42 | constant |
| MP10 | $\Delta X(200)$; $a$, ratio to PM10 at $N = 128$ | $-1.00002$; $-1.00001$ | $-1$ |
| PM8–PM20 | exponent of $a(d_0)$ | $-2.03 \pm 0.01$ | $-2$ |
| PM8, PM10, PM12, PM16, PM20 | $a\, d_0^2/\bar{M}$ | 1.031, 1.011, 1.003, 1.001, 1.002 | 1 |
| E0.64, PM20, E1.34, E1.57 | exponent of $a(\bar{M})$ | $0.97 \pm 0.06$ | 1 |
| E0.64, PM20, E1.34, E1.57 | $a\, d_0^2/\bar{M}$ | 1.024, 0.997, 0.989, 0.987 | 1 |
| R0.60, R0.80, R1.33 | $C$ ratio, partner changed | 0.618, 0.810, 0.756 | 0.600, 0.803, 0.747 |
| R0.60, R0.80, R1.33 | $C$ ratio, partner unchanged | 1.028, 1.011, 1.001 | 1 |
| R0.60, R0.80, PM10, R1.33 | $\lvert M_-\rvert/M_+$ at which $d(200) = d_0$ | $1.00 \pm 0.03$ | 1 |
| PP10, all $N$; MM10, all $N$ | largest centroid displacement | $7.8 \times 10^{-4}$; $5.3 \times 10^{-4}$ | 0 |
| P; M | largest core displacement over $t \le 200$ | $1.8 \times 10^{-3}$; $1.6 \times 10^{-3}$ | 0 |
| PM10-L128 | exponent of $\lvert\Psi_4\rvert_{\ell=2}(R)$ | $-4.8$ | $-1$ if radiative |
| PM10-L128; -tol; -AMR; -$\eta$2 | change of $\Delta X(200)$ from PM10 at $N = 128$ | $-4.2\%$; $+0.0015\%$; $+0.0008\%$; $-0.007\%$ | 0 |
| M-t1000 | decay of the peak field per 100 time units | 0.63% | – |

rection Bondi's argument predicts. When the negative-mass star is the heavier, the positive-mass star in front is pushed away more strongly than the negative-mass star behind it is pulled, and the separation grows; when the negative-mass star is the lighter, the separation shrinks. Across the four pairs, the change of the separation at $t = 200$ is monotonic in $|M_-|/M_+$ and crosses zero at $1.00 \pm 0.03$, as predicted. The error is the spread between ways of measuring the separation (between the barycentres, between the cores, as a proper distance, and averaged over $190 \le t \le 200$).

## VI. GRAVITATIONAL RADIATION

Does the accelerating pair radiate? The exact solutions for uniformly accelerated pairs are radiative [2, 3], and negative-mass binaries have been proposed as sources of anomalous signals, dipole radiation among them [39]. In our model dipole radiation is absent for the same reason as in ordinary general relativity. The source of gravity is the signed stress-energy tensor, which is conserved (Sec. II), so the time derivative of the signed mass dipole equals the signed momentum $P$, which stays zero (Sec. V A). Independently, $\Psi_4$ has spin weight $-2$, so its multipoles begin at $\ell = 2$. The leading candidate is therefore quadrupole radiation from the accelerating pair. For a pair with zero momentum, the signed mass quadrupole along the axis is $Q \simeq 2\bar{M} d\, X(t)$, so at constant separation and acceleration its second time derivative, $\ddot{Q} = 2\bar{M} a d$, is constant. Computing $Q$ from the tracked positions of the two stars, we find $\ddot{Q} = 4.5 \times 10^{-5}$, against $4.4 \times 10^{-5}$ predicted, constant to 7% over $20 \le t \le 190$. The quadrupole luminosity is proportional to $\dddot{Q}^{\,2}$ and vanishes for constant $\ddot{Q}$. From the measured bound $|\ddot{Q}| \le 6 \times 10^{-8}$, the energy radiated over the run is at most of order $10^{-14}$, ten orders of magnitude below the pair's total mass, $M_+ + M_- = 5.5 \times 10^{-5}$.

We extract $\Psi_4$ on spheres at $R = 16$ to 40 in PM10-L128, whose domain is twice as large (Fig. 8). The $\ell = 2$ amplitude falls as $R^{-4.8}$, and $R\,|\Psi_4|$ drops by a factor 31 across the four spheres, where an outgoing wave would keep it constant. All four spheres therefore lie in the near zone, where $\Psi_4$ reflects the curvature of the source rather than a radiated flux, and we detect no radiation, in agreement with the estimate above. The radiative regime needs much higher speeds than the $0.03c$ the pair reaches by $t = 200$.

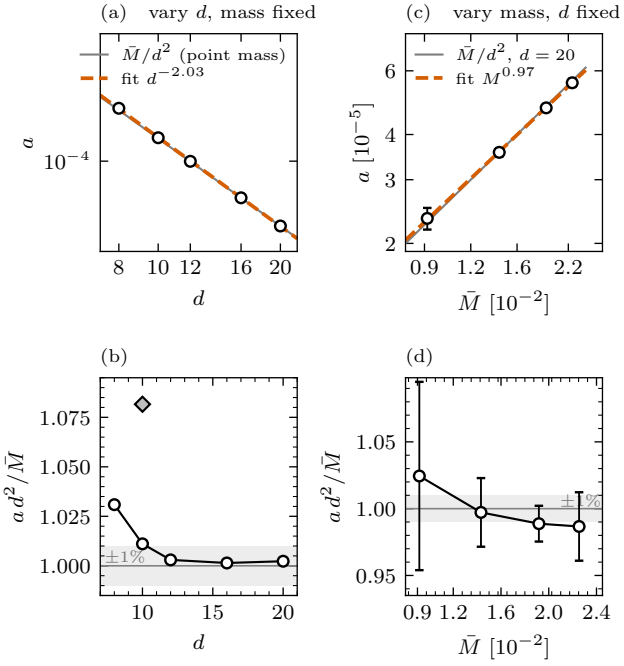



FIG. 5. (a) Acceleration $a$ against initial separation $d_0$ at $N = 128$ (circles), with a power-law fit (dashed) and $\bar{M}/d^2$ (grey). (b) $a\,d^2/\bar{M}$ against $d_0$; the diamond is the $N = 256$ value at $d_0 = 10$. (c) $a$ against $\bar{M}$ for the four equal-mass pairs at $d_0 = 20$, with a power-law fit (dashed) and $\bar{M}/d^2$ (grey); (d) their $a\,d^2/\bar{M}$. Error bars: half the spread of fits over four disjoint time windows. The acceleration scales as $d^{-2.03\pm0.01}$ and as $\bar{M}^{0.97\pm0.06}$.

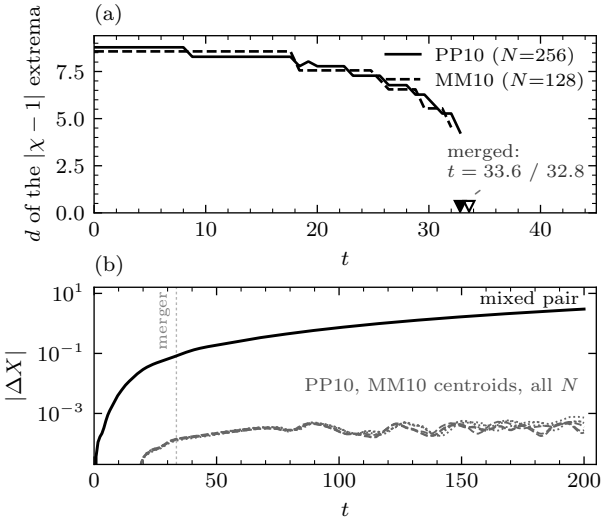



FIG. 6. The same-sign controls. (a) Distance between the two extrema of $|\chi - 1|$ against time for PP10 ($N = 256$, solid) and MM10 ($N = 128$, dashed). (b) $|\Delta X|$ of the mixed pair and the centroid displacement of every PP10 and MM10 simulation. Although gravity attracts the stars of PP10 and repels those of MM10, both pairs merge at the same time, through the attraction of their shared field, and their centroids stay below $8 \times 10^{-4}$. Movies: Videos 3, youtu.be/jsp-Tv-f68Y, and 4, youtu.be/_J8jfzUk-m4.

## VII. CONVERGENCE AND SYSTEMATIC CHECKS

### A. Resolution

We evolved PM10 at $N = 128$, 192 and 256 (Fig. 9a). The two highest resolutions agree to 0.4% in $\Delta X(200)$ and to 0.5% in $a$, and their difference is the error bar quoted in Sec. V A. The lowest resolution lies 4% below in $\Delta X(200)$ and 7% below in $a$. It lies outside the convergent regime: the differences between successive resolutions have opposite signs. The simulations at other separations and masses ran at $N = 128$ and enter only through exponents and ratios (Sec. V C). Appendix A gives the constraint norms.

### B. Other numerical choices

Simulations that change one setting of PM10 at $N = 128$ test the other numerical choices; Table III lists the changes of $\Delta X(200)$. A 4.4 times tighter elliptic-solver tolerance, adaptive mesh refinement and a doubled shift damping $\eta$ each change $\Delta X(200)$ by less than 0.01%, so the truncation error at $N = 128$ comes from the evolution, not from the initial-data solve. No refined level is created, because $|\chi - 1|$ never reaches the refinement threshold of 0.02, and doubling $\eta$ changes the shift itself by 5%. Doubling the side of the domain at the same grid spacing changes $\Delta X(200)$ by 4%, so the outer boundary does not drive the motion. Fitting $a$ over the last two thirds of each run instead of $t \geq 5$ changes individual accelerations by 1 to 3% and leaves the exponents, the ratios of $C$ and the zero crossing of Sec. V F unchanged. For the same-sign pairs, whose total mass is $2M_+$ or $2M_-$, the conformally flat outer boundary condition of the elliptic solve is less accurate, and their solves stop at a relative residual near $10^{-5}$; their constraint norms stay bounded through the merger (Appendix A).

### C. Gauge

$\Delta X$ and $d$ are coordinate quantities, so we checked the gauge directly. The shift at the two cores is nearly antisymmetric, so its mean, the only part that could move the pair as a whole, stays below $1.1 \times 10^{-5}$, against a midpoint velocity of $3 \times 10^{-2}$. Integrated over the run, it accounts for 0.013% of $\Delta X$. The proper distance between the cores, which does not depend on the choice of spatial coordinates along the axis, changes by 0.24% over $t \leq 200$.

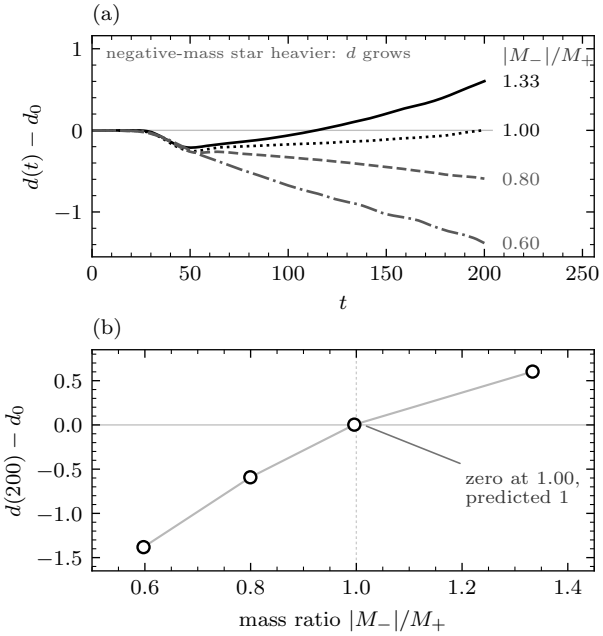



FIG. 7. (a) Change of the separation, $d(t) - d_0$, for the pairs at $d_0 = 10$ with $|M_-|/M_+ = 0.60$, 0.80, 1.00 and 1.33 (R0.60, R0.80, PM10, R1.33); all share a transient near $t \approx 50$, so the change is read at late times. (b) $d(200) - d_0$ against $|M_-|/M_+$. The separation grows when the negative-mass star is the heavier and shrinks when it is the lighter; the change crosses zero at $|M_-|/M_+ = 1.00 \pm 0.03$, as predicted.

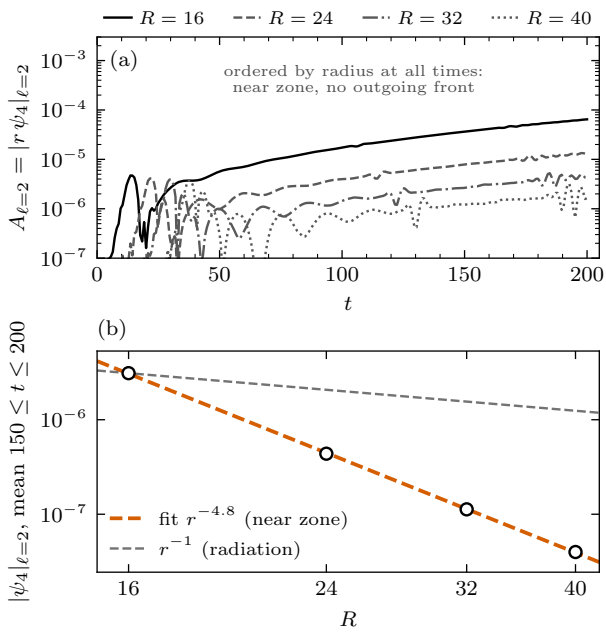



FIG. 8. (a) $\ell = 2$ amplitude of $\Psi_4$ on spheres of radius $R = 16$, 24, 32 and 40 in PM10-L128. (b) Its mean over $150 \le t \le 200$ against $R$, with the fit $\propto R^{-4.8}$ (dashed) and the $R^{-1}$ fall-off of radiation (grey). The amplitude falls far faster than radiation would, so all four spheres lie in the near zone and no radiated flux is detected.

### D. Separation after $t = 200$

At $N = 128$ the separation grows after $t \approx 200$: it reaches 11.8 at $t = 400$ in PM10-t400 and keeps growing in PM10-rec and PM10-off, as the acceleration of the trailing negative-mass star decreases and reverses near $t \approx 530$. With equal masses both stars accelerate equally at every separation, so nothing restores the separation, and any small difference between the two accelerations accumulates. The 0.4% mismatch of the reference pair has the wrong sign, since it would shrink the separation. PM10-rec, whose domain follows the pair, and PM10-off, whose domain stays fixed, agree on the separation to 0.5% up to $t = 500$. Only the resolution changes the effect: the change of the core separation at $t = 200$ falls from 0.107 to 0.029 to 0.013 between $N = 128$ and 256, eightfold for a factor two in grid spacing. We therefore quote pair quantities for $t \le 200$ only, where the change at $N = 256$ is 0.13%.

## VIII. CONCLUSIONS

We evolved Bondi's pair of positive and negative active mass as a full initial-value problem in 3+1 numerical relativity, with two complex scalar fields that differ only in the sign with which they source the Einstein equations. Released from rest, a pair with equal $|M_{\rm ADM}|$ accelerates as a single object, at a constant rate and constant separation, while its total signed momentum stays zero. The acceleration follows Bondi's Newtonian law in both separation and mass, each star responds to its partner's mass, and exchanging the two stars reverses the motion. The same-sign pairs and the isolated stars, which have no mass dipole, stay at rest.

We detect no gravitational radiation: the signed mass dipole stays constant, the second time derivative of the quadrupole is constant, and every extraction sphere lies in the near zone. The negative-mass star exists as constraint-satisfying, asymptotically flat initial data. It neither collapses nor disperses over the evolved time, 400 time units in a pair and 1000 alone, although it slowly relaxes outward.

These results hold for head-on pairs released from rest, in the weak-field regime (compactness $3\times10^{-3}$), at speeds up to $0.06c$, and over the evolved times. Two extensions follow. Releases with a transverse offset would test whether the pair is stable against sideways perturbations. Relativistic speeds would test the question that motivates this configuration: the pair's total mass is only 0.4% of either star's, and no positive-mass theorem bounds the energy it could radiate. Here the speed is limited by the resolution rather than by the length of the run, so that measurement needs finer grids; near $0.3c$ it would provide a concrete source for the signals proposed in Ref. [39]. Our results do not address whether such matter exists.

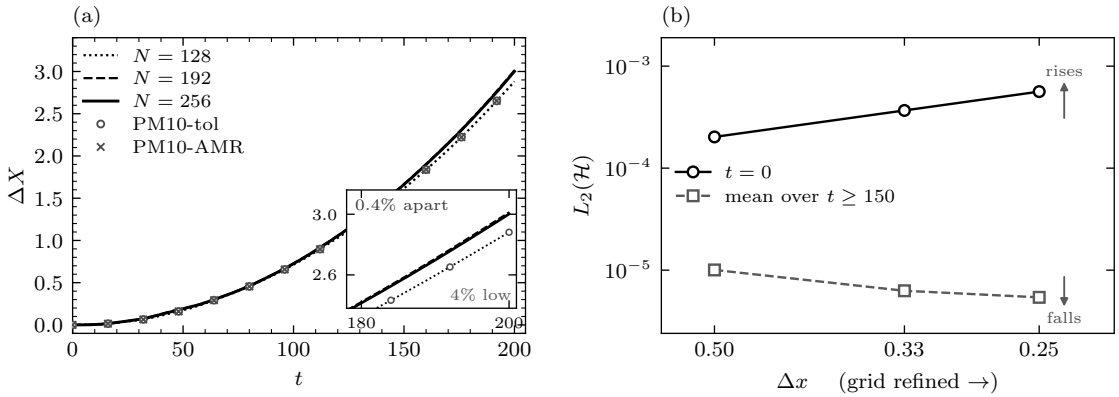



FIG. 9. (a) $\Delta X$ of PM10 at $N = 128$, 192 and 256, and of PM10-tol (circles) and PM10-AMR (crosses). Inset: the end of the run. (b) $L_2$ norm of the Hamiltonian constraint over the whole domain, at $t = 0$ and averaged over $t \geq 150$, against $\Delta x$; the $t = 0$ values are dominated by the cells next to the outer boundary (Appendix A). The two highest resolutions agree to 0.4% in $\Delta X(200)$, and $N = 128$ lies 4% below.

## DATA AVAILABILITY

The data that support this study are openly available in the repository of Ref. [44], under `results/bondi-dipole-runaway`, archived on Zenodo (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23245933). For every simulation they include the time series of all diagnostics, the constraint norms, the $\Psi_4$ multipoles, the elliptic-solver history and the parameter files; they also include the radial profiles of the stars and the script that regenerates every figure and prints every number quoted here. The initial-data code (`GRTresna` [25]) and the evolution code (`GRTeclyn` [23, 24, 26]) are in the same repository. The Supplemental Material contains movies of the reference simulation (Video 1), of PM10-t400 (Video 2) and of the same-sign controls PP10 and MM10 (Videos 3 and 4).

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### Appendix A: Constraint norms

Every constraint solve of a mixed pair converges monotonically and stops below its tolerance, which scales with the grid spacing: the relative residual of the Hamiltonian constraint is $8.6 \times 10^{-6}$ at $N = 128$ after 13 nonlinear iterations and $8.7 \times 10^{-7}$ at $N = 256$ after 16. Figure 10 shows the $L_2$ norms of the Hamiltonian and momentum constraints over the evolution domain, in units $G = c = m = 1$; the domain is mostly vacuum, so norms relative to the size of the matter terms would be dominated by small denominators. The large values at $t = 0$, which grow with resolution, come from the cells next to the outer boundary of the evolution domain, which is cut from the larger domain of the elliptic solve: the norm that leaves out the four cells next to the boundary is a hundred times smaller at $t = 0$ and decreases with resolution. This boundary transient decays by an order of magnitude within $t \approx 3$, before the fit window of Eq. (8) opens. The norms then stay bounded for the rest of the run at every resolution, as they do for PP10 through its merger.

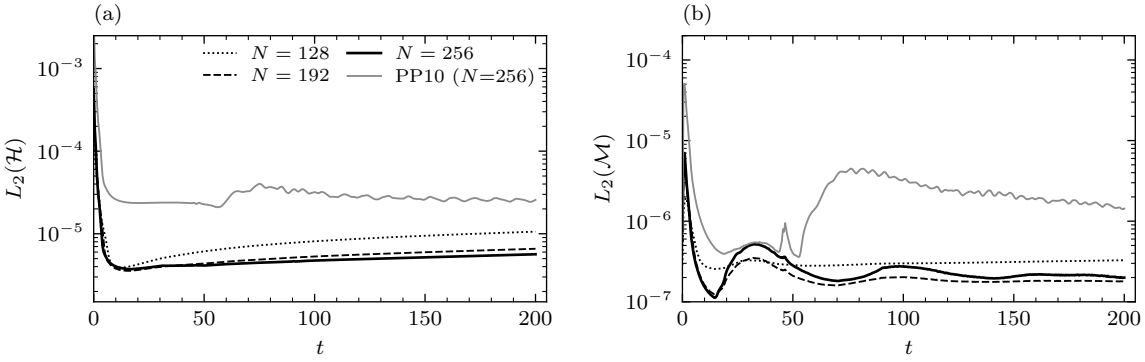



FIG. 10. $L_2$ norms over the evolution domain of (a) the Hamiltonian and (b) the momentum constraint for PM10 at $N = 128$, 192 and 256 (line styles as in Fig. 9) and for PP10 at $N = 256$ (grey). After a transient from the outer boundary that decays within $t \approx 3$, the norms stay bounded for the whole run.


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